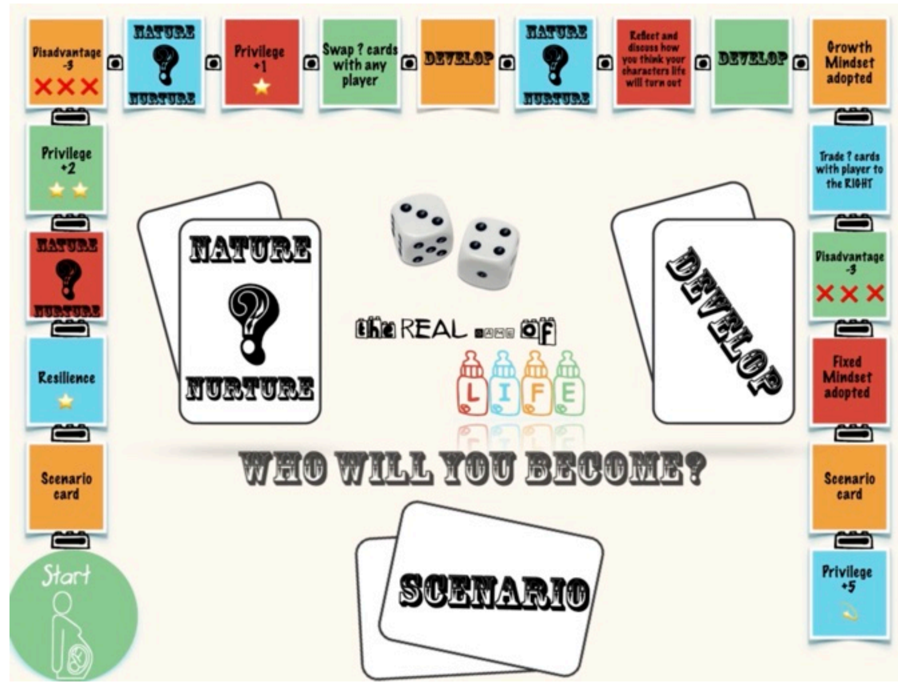
What do children know about gender, SES, and race?

T/Th 9:35-10:25am

Professor Casey Lew-Williams
Kennedy Casey, Abby Fergus, Sarah Joo, Chantal Valdivia, Claire Whiting

Enjoy the media/art presentations in your last precept!



Post-precept wrap-up: Warneken & Tomasello (2006)

?

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each category (Fig. 1). They handed him several out-of-reach objects (but not if he had discarded them deliberately); they completed his stacking of books after his failed attempt (but not if his placement of the books appeared to meet his goal); they opened the door of a cabinet for him when his hands were full (but not if he struggled toward the top of the cabinet); and they retrieved an inaccessible object for him by opening a box using a means he was unaware of (but not if he had thrown the object inside the box on purpose). Analyzed by individual, 22 of the 24 infants helped in at least one of the tasks. It is noteworthy that they did so in almost all cases immediately (average latency = 5.2 s), before the adult either looked to them or verbalized his problem (84% of helping acts within the initial 10-s phase). Thus, the experimenter never verbally asked for help, and for the vast majority of helping acts, eye contact (as a subtle means of soliciting help) was also unnecessary.

Experimental studies on altruistic behaviors in nonhuman primates are scarce. There are anecdotal reports of possible instances of helping (*15–17*) and some experiments demonstrating empathic intervention by various monkey species when another individual is displaying emotional distress (but no experiments with apes) (*18*). However, there are no studies, to our knowledge, of nonhuman primates helping others who are struggling to achieve their goals (instrumental helping) (*19*, *20*). In two recent experiments, chimpanzees were given the opportunity to deliver food to a conspecific (*21*, *22*), but again that conspecific was not trying to solve a problem in which the subject could help instrumentally [see also (*23*)]. Results were negative. But it is possible that altruism would be more likely when it involves objects other than food, because chimpanzees often compete over food and the drive to acquire food for themselves might preclude their capacity to act on behalf of others. In the current study, therefore, we gave the same basic tasks of instrumental helping

Altruistic Helping in Human Infants and Young Chimpanzees

Felix Warneken* and Michael Tomasello

Human beings routinely help others to achieve their goals, even when the helper receives no immediate benefit and the person helped is a stranger. Such altruistic behaviors (toward non-kin) are extremely rare evolutionarily, with some theorists even proposing that they are uniquely human. Here we show that human children as young as 18 months of age (prelinguistic or just-linguistic) quite readily help others to achieve their goals in a variety of different situations. This requires both an understanding of others' goals and an altruistic motivation to help. In addition, we demonstrate similar though less robust skills and motivations in three young chimpanzees.

Helping is an extremely interesting phenomenon both cognitively and motivationally. Cognitively, to help someone solve a problem, one must know something about the goal the other is attempting to achieve as well as the current obstacles to that goal. Motivationally, exerting effort to help another person—with no immediate benefit to oneself—is costly, and such altruism (toward non-kin) is extremely rare evolutionarily. Indeed, some researchers have claimed that humans are altruistic in ways that even our closest primate relatives are not. A powerful method to test this idea is to directly compare human infants and our closest primate relatives (chimpanzees) on their propensity to help. Such a comparison may enable us to distinguish aspects of altruism that were already present in the common ancestor of chimpanzees and humans from aspects of altruism that have evolved only in the human lineage. To date, no experimental studies have systematically tested human infants and chimpanzees in a similar set of helping situations.

A number of studies have demonstrated that young children show concern (empathy) for others in distress. Preschool-age children and even infants (1 to 2 years of age) occasionally attempt to respond to the emotional needs of others, for example, by comforting someone

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Additional studies about children's prosocial behavior

Interesting followup finding #1: kids who receive a reward for helping are less likely to help in the future. They're more likely to help if they receive nothing.

#2: toddlers need to have good fine/gross motor skills and turn-taking skills in order to help in the first place. (dynamic systems theory…)

#3: Kids help more if they've just experienced awe (vs. joy)

#4: 5-year-olds experience greater reward from helping if there's an audience. Helping = reputation management? 🙁

(Warneken & Tomasello, 2008; Koster, et al., 2019; Chai, Yin, Shen, & He, 2024; Hepach & Tomasello, 2022)


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RACIST TENDENCIES

Gender

Socioeconomic status

Race

A pyrotechnic device at a gender reveal party sparked one of the California wildfires, burning over 8,600 acres

By Hollie Silverman, Amir Vera and Cheri Mossburg, CNN

Updated 8:46 PM ET, Mon September 7, 2020

Gender concepts: Stereotypes

Gender concepts: Stereotypes

“Math class is tough.”
“You look great.”
“Want to go shopping? Okay, meet me at the mall.”

“Vengeance is mine”
“Attack!”
“Take the Jeep and get some ammo, fast.”

(Kuhn et al., 1978)

Seeing gender

- **Question**: do infants notice the difference between male and female faces?

(Quinn et al., 2002)

Gender preferences in natural interaction

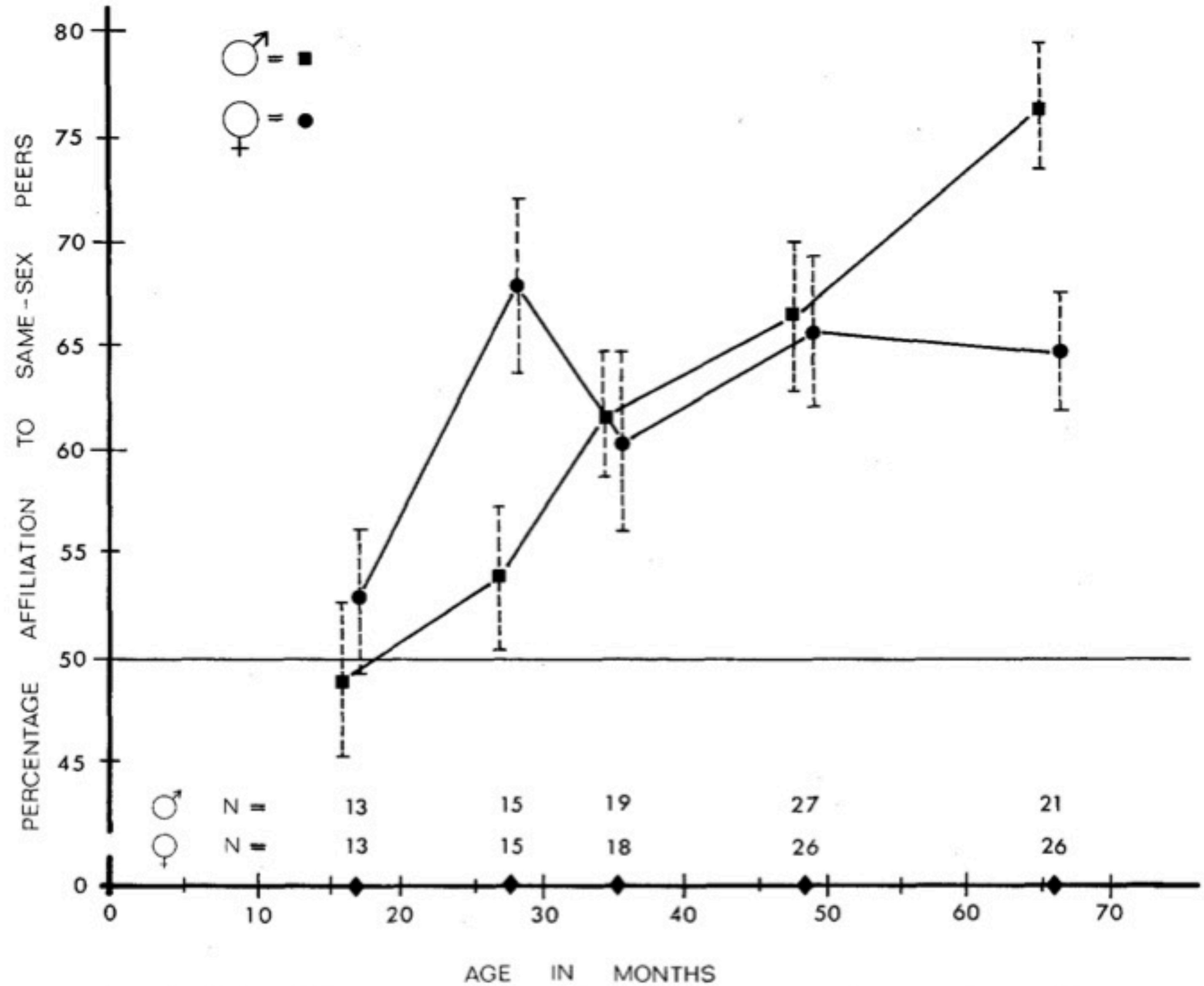
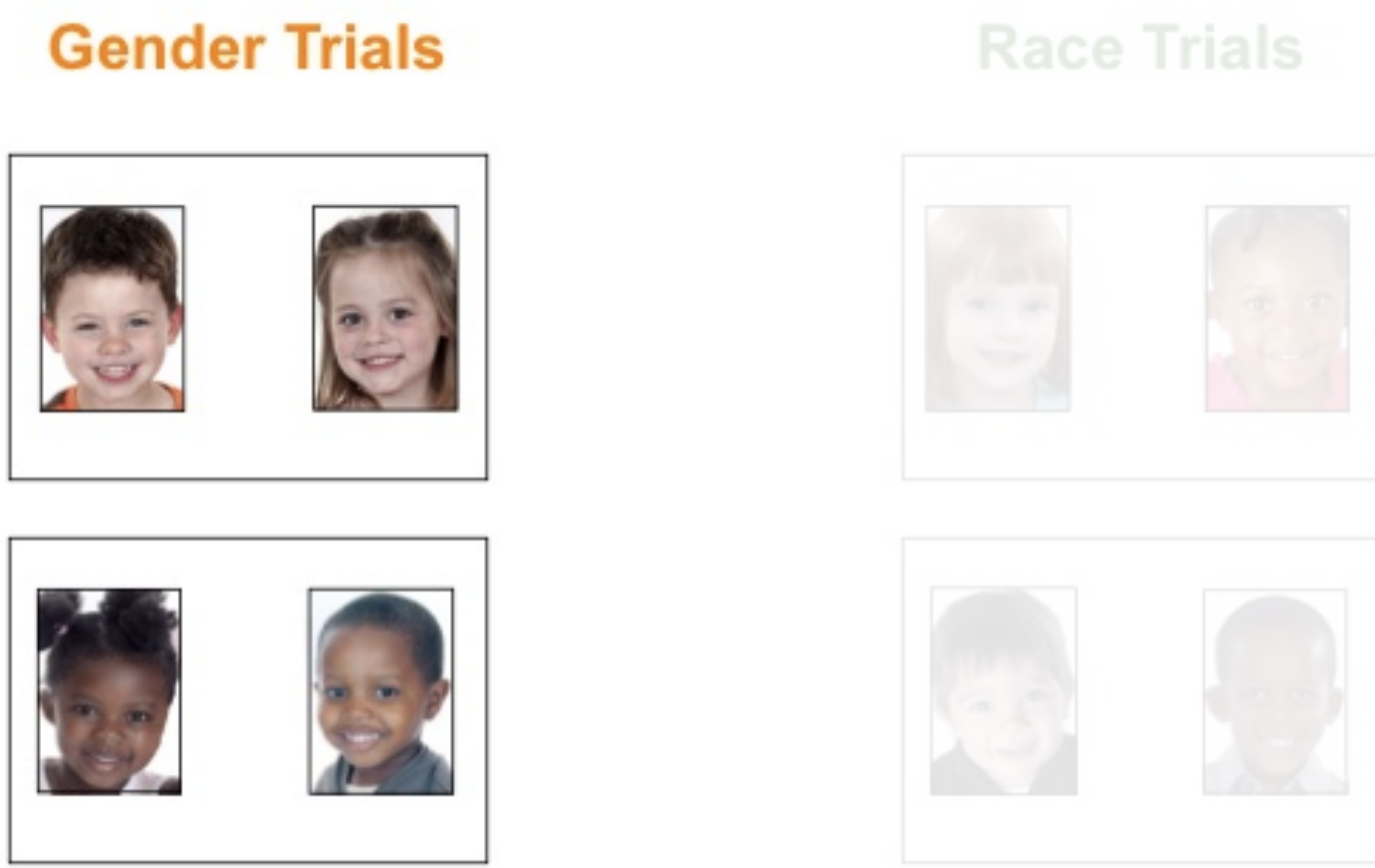


FIG. 1.—Mean affiliative activity directed to same-sex peers as a function of age and sex

(La Freniere et al., 1984)

Gender identity in the lab

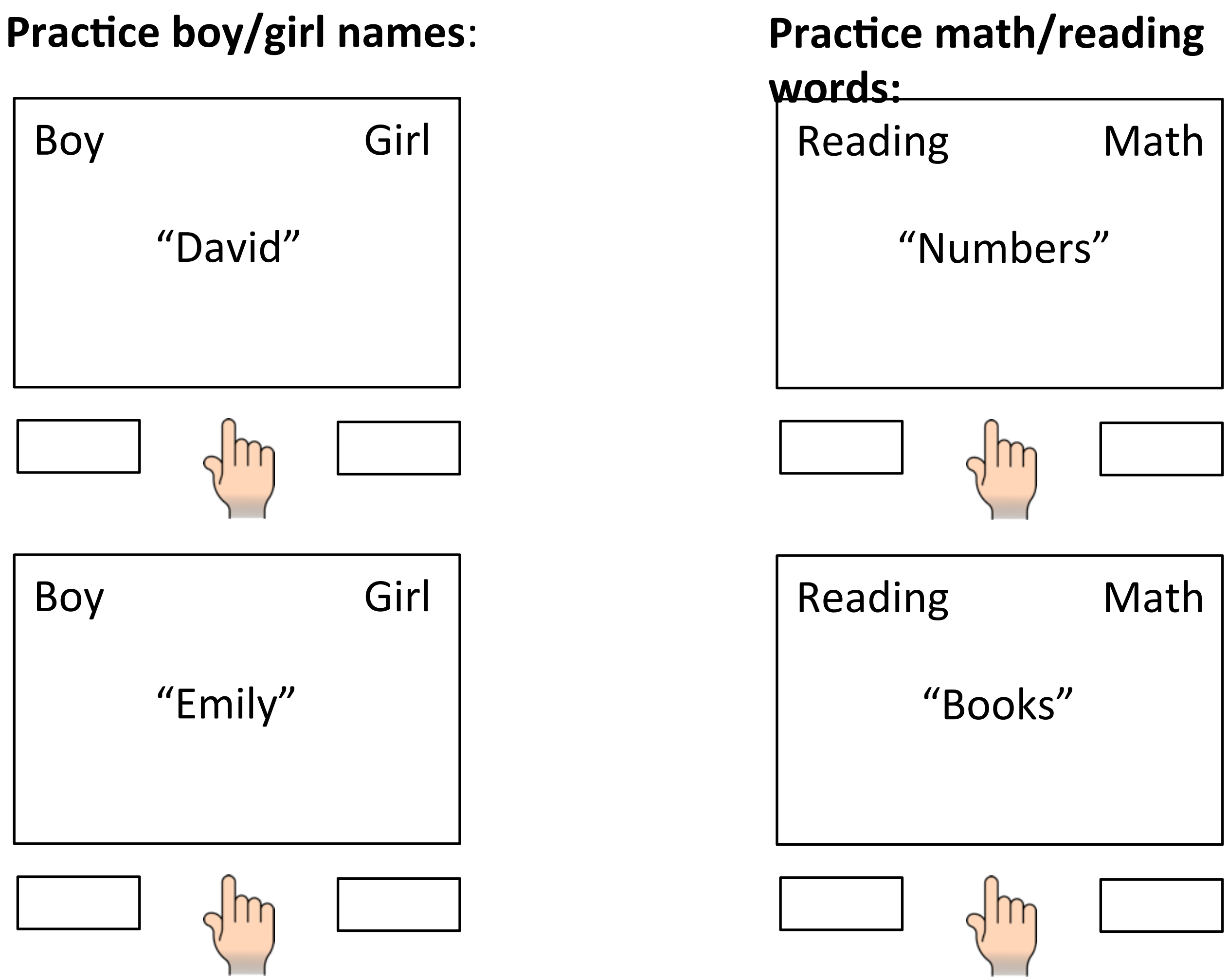


"Which child would you want as your friend?"

(Shutts et al., 2013)

Gender stereotypes: The Implicit Association Test

- **Question**: Are young children aware of math/gender stereotypes?



(Cvencek et al., 2011)

Gender stereotypes: The Implicit Association Test

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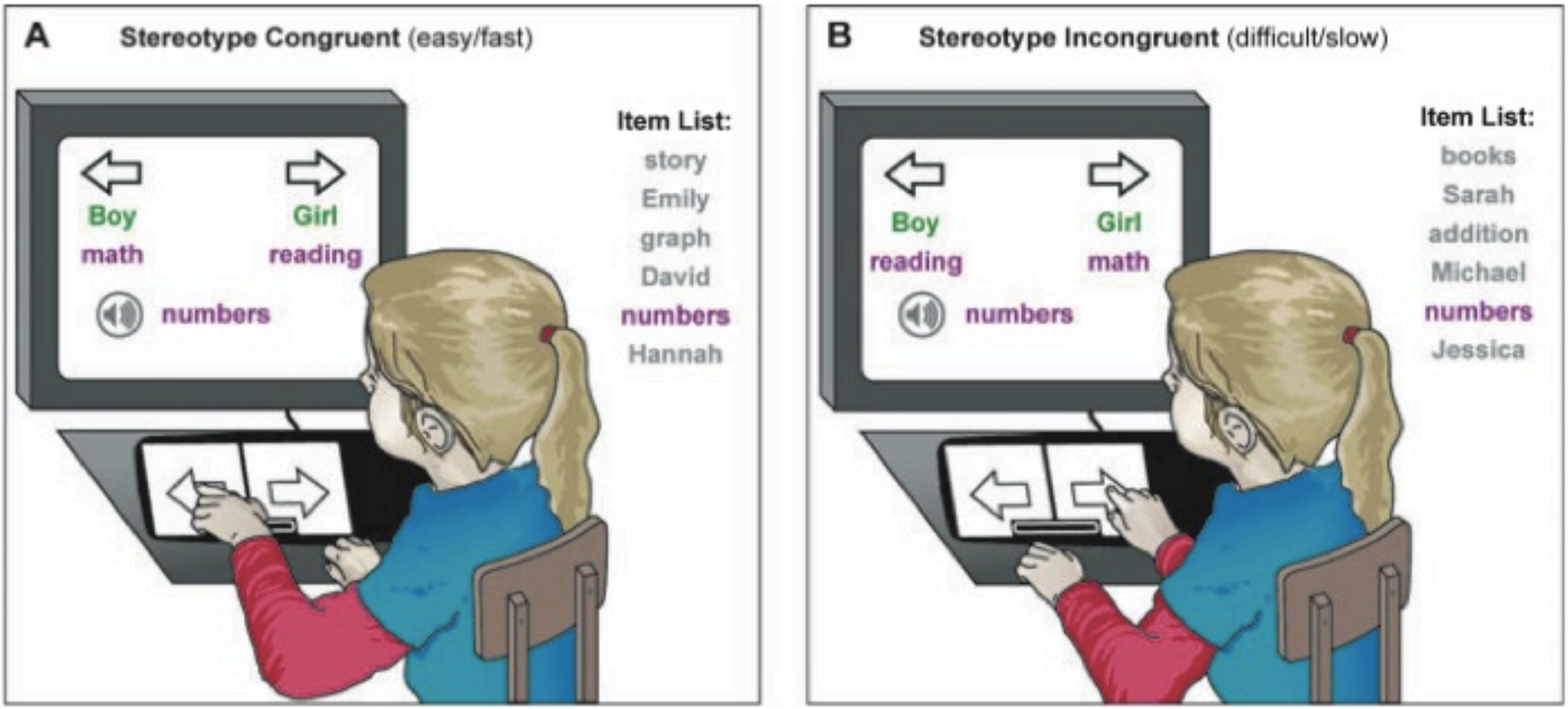


Go try an IAT test! You're biased too!
https://implicit.harvard.edu/

(Cvencek et al., 2011)

Why is gender so important to kids?

- **Evolution?**

- **Socialization?**

    - Media, toys, clothes

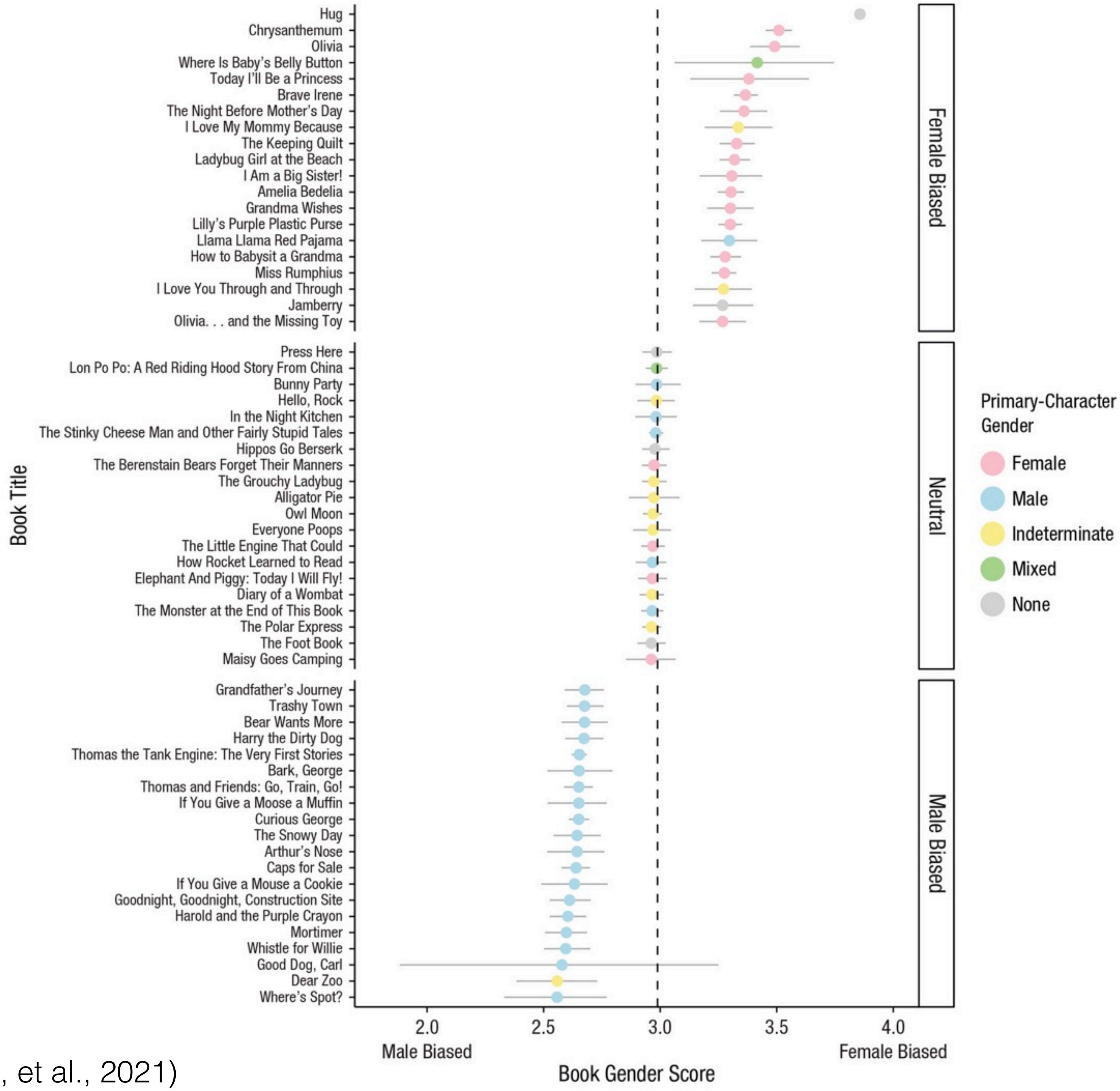



    - Language
        - *Say hi to the nice man.*
        - *Aren't you a sweet little girl!*
        - *Good morning boys and girls.*
        - *The girls should sit on this side.*

    - Books?

(Cosmides et al., 2003; Bigler & Liben, 2007)

Children's books are an early source of gender stereotypes



(Lewis, Borkenhagen, et al., 2021)

Why is gender so important to kids?

- **Question**: does dividing kids by gender in a classroom increase gender stereotyping?

(Bigler, 1995)

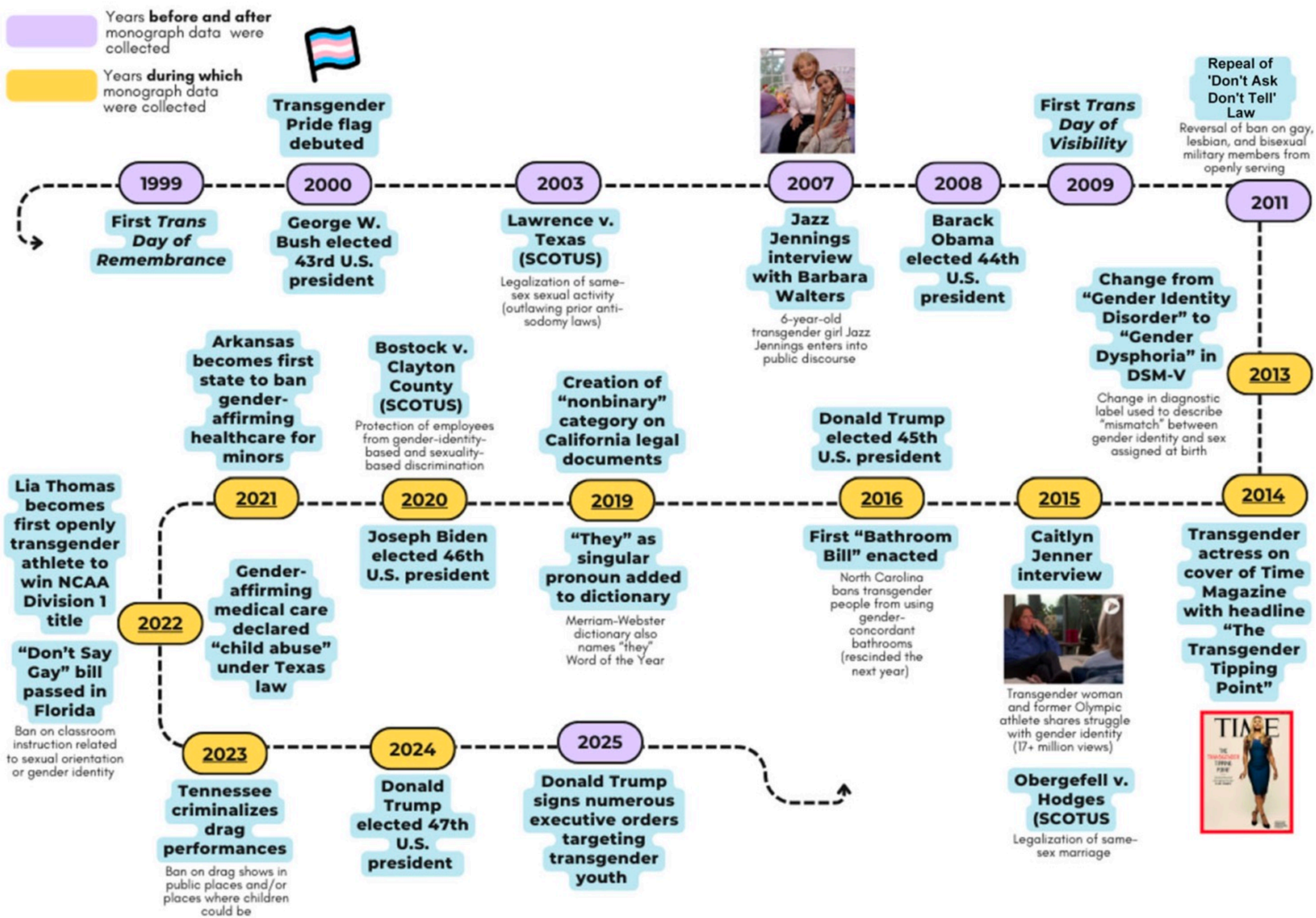
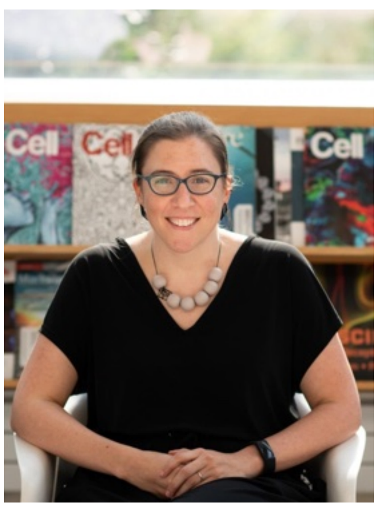


FIGURE 1.—Key legal, historical, cultural, and linguistic LGBTQ milestones.

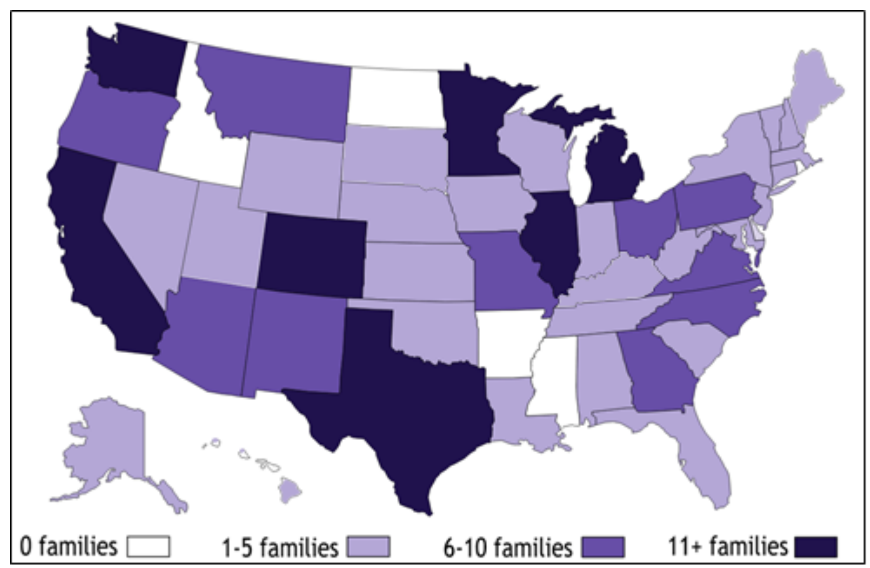
(deMayo et al., 2025)

Gender cognition in transgender children

- **Question**: do transgender elementary school kids view themselves in terms of <u>expressed gender</u> or <u>natal sex</u>?



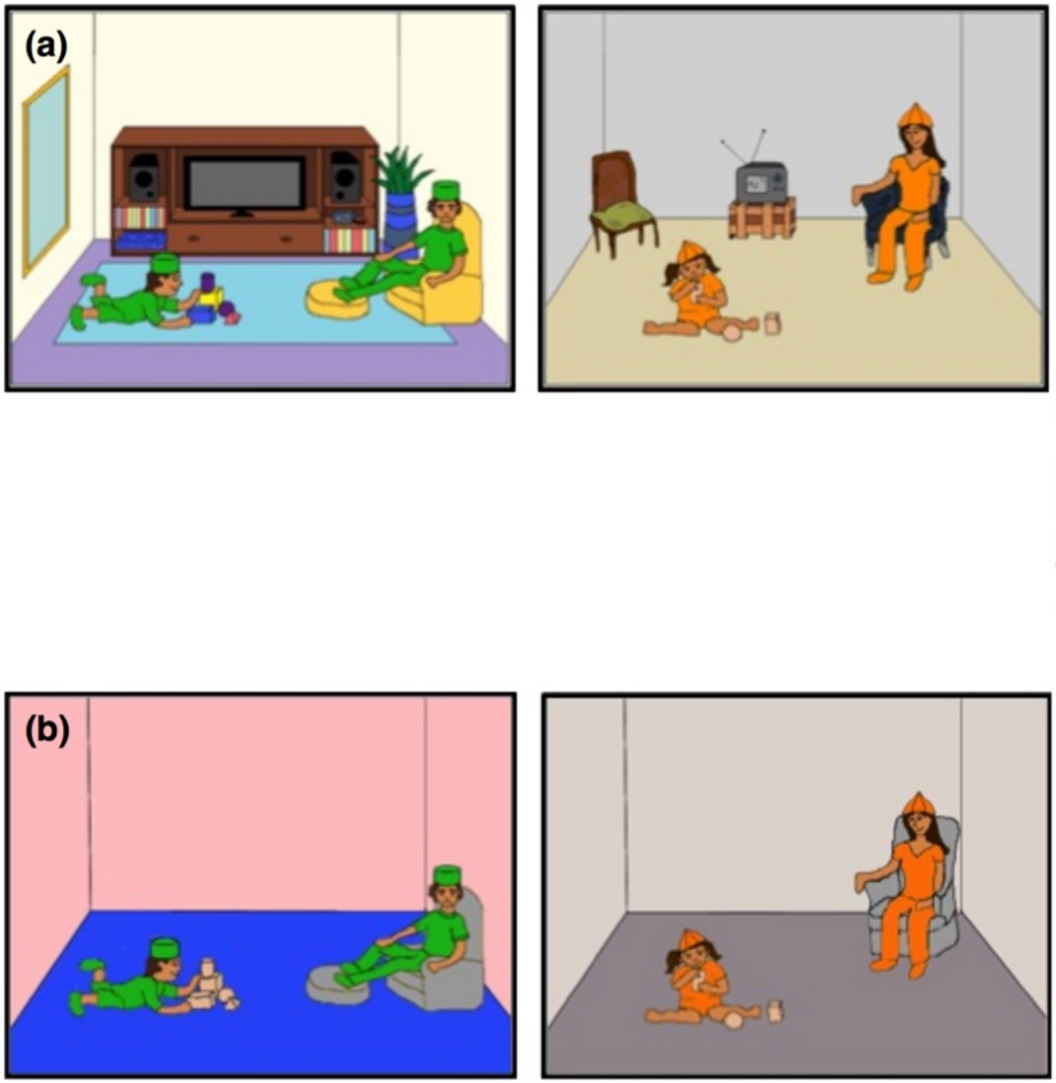
HUman Diversity Lab

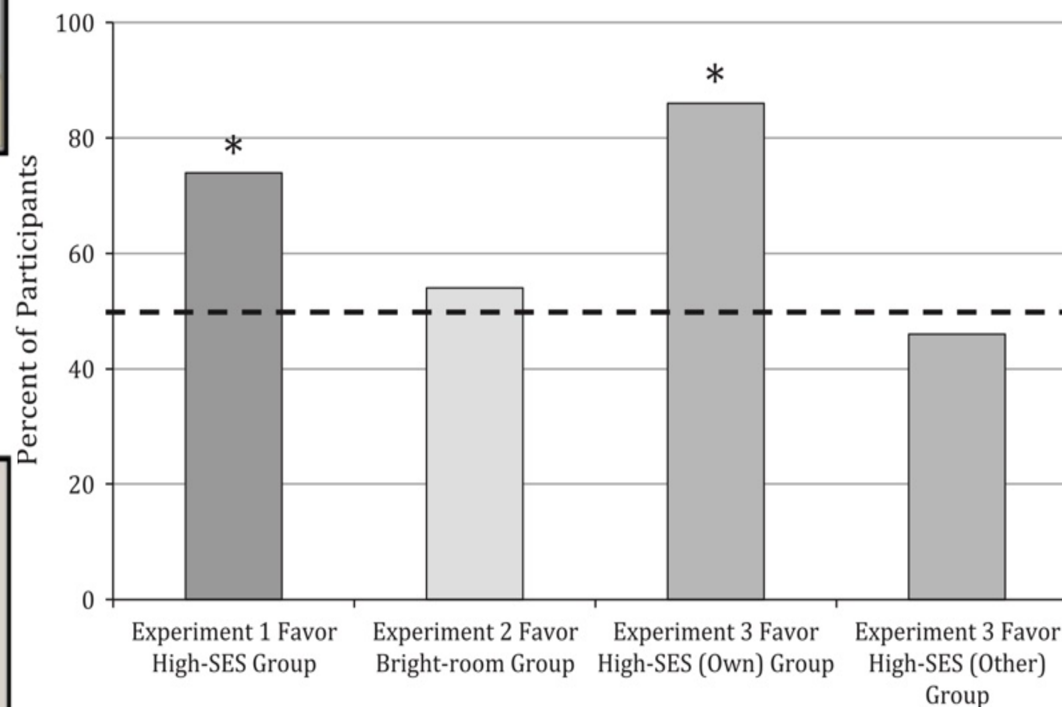


(Olson, Key, & Eaton, 2015)

Socioeconomic status

SES & social preferences





(Horwitz, Shutts, & Olson, 2014; Rizzo, Roberts, Rhodes, 2024)

Race

Seeing race

- **Question**: do infants notice race in faces?

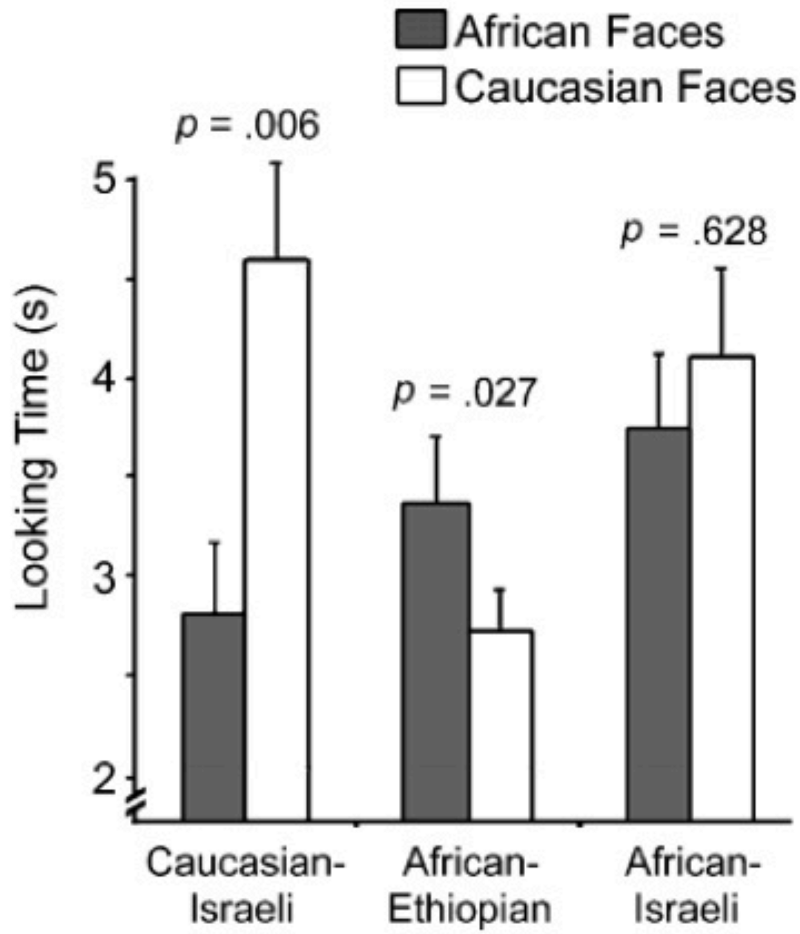


Fig. 1. Examples of the face stimuli (a) and looking times (in seconds) of the Caucasian Israeli, African Ethiopian, and African Israeli infants. Whiskers represent standard errors.

(Bar-Haim et al., 2006; Kelly, Quinn, Slater, Lee, Gibson, Smith, Ge, & Pascalis, 2005, 2007)

Race-based social preferences take a while to emerge

- **Question 1**: do <u>infants</u> prefer to interact with same-race people?
- **Question 2**: do <u>2-year-olds</u> prefer to give things to same-race people?
- **Question 3**: do <u>5-year-olds</u> prefer to associate with same-race people?

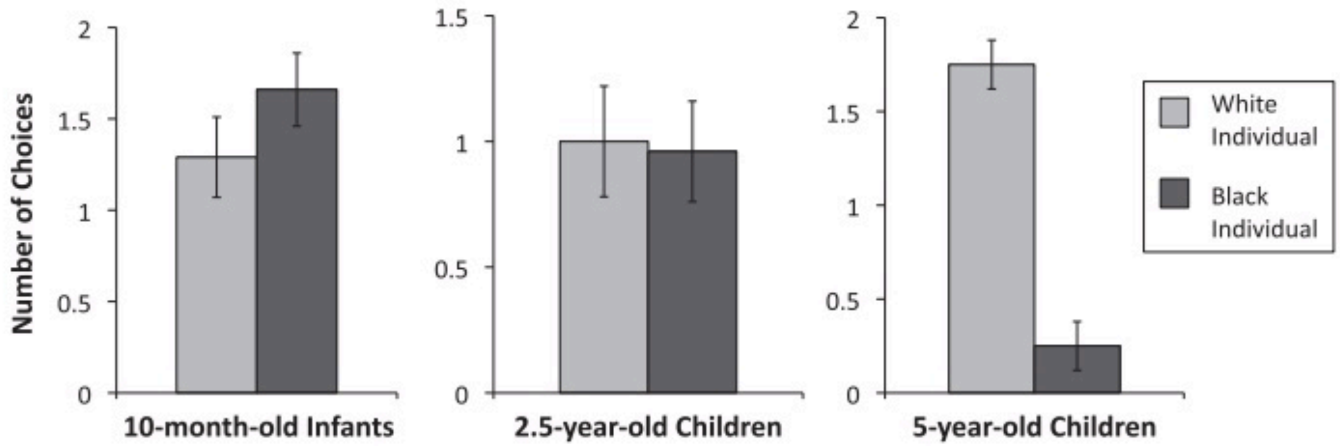
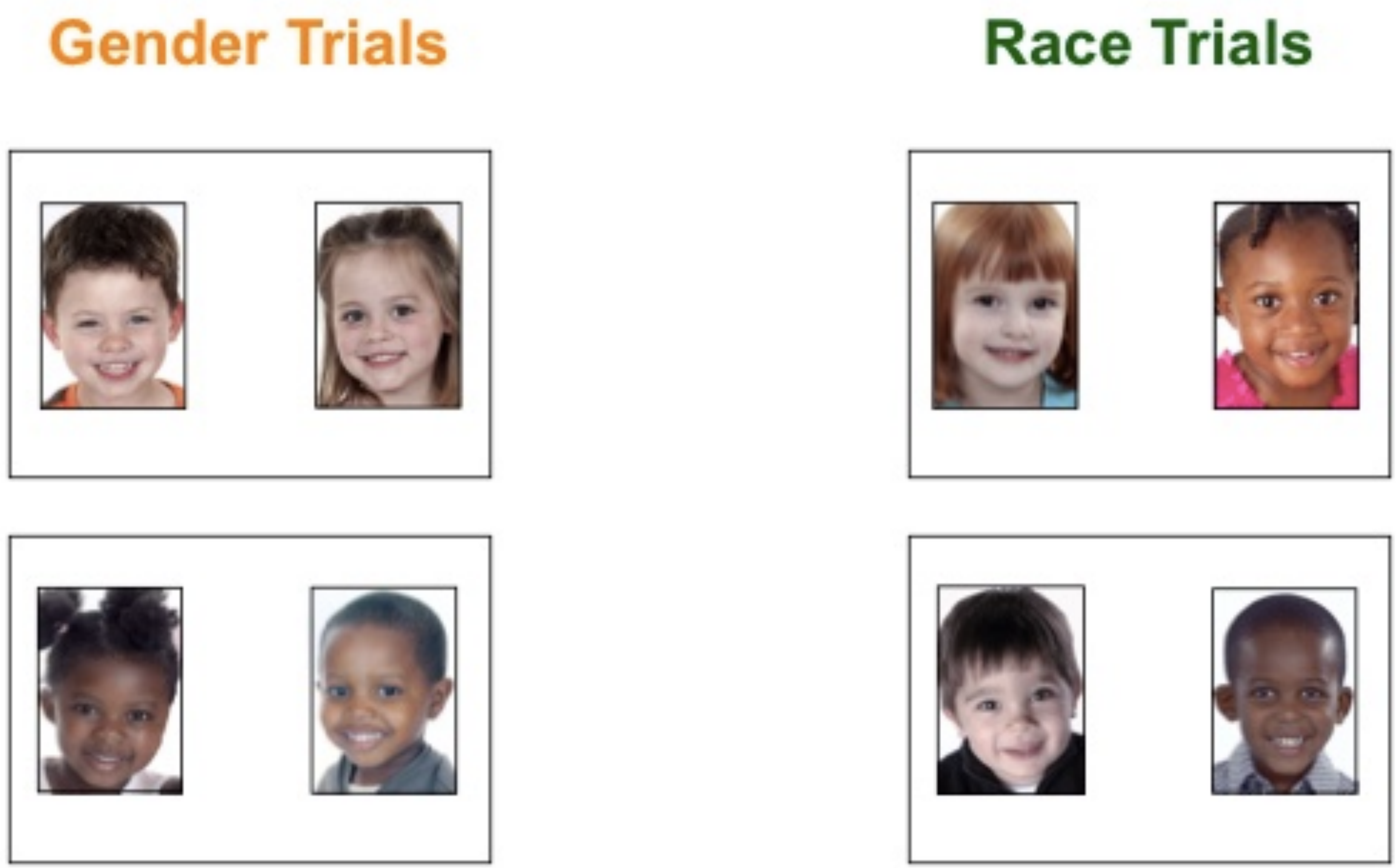


Fig. 2. Number of trials on which infants and children chose the White or Black individual in Experiment 1 (left), 2 (center) and 3 (right). Er
represent standard error.

(Kinzler & Spelke, 2011)

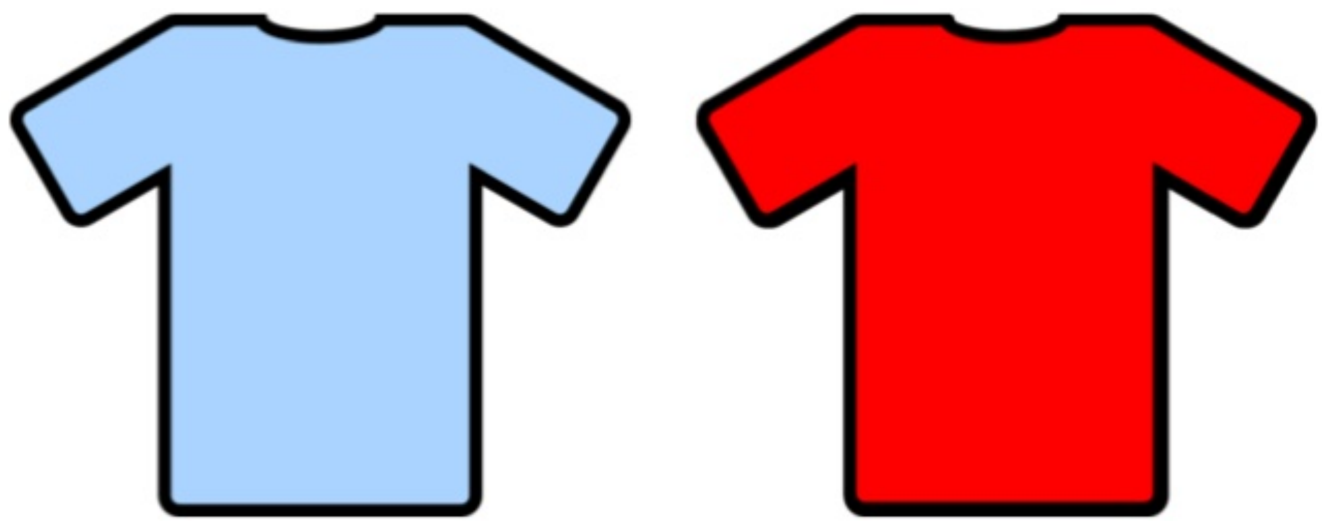
Race-based social preferences



"Which child would you want as your friend?"

(Shutts et al., 2013; Golari, Ghahremani, Greenwood, Gabrieli, & Eberhardt, 2021)

Ingroup favoritism based on ‘minimal groups’



(Tajfel, 1970s; Dunham et al., 2011)

Asymmetries in racial attitudes

(Clark & Clark doll studies, 1930s-1950s)

Asymmetries in racial attitudes

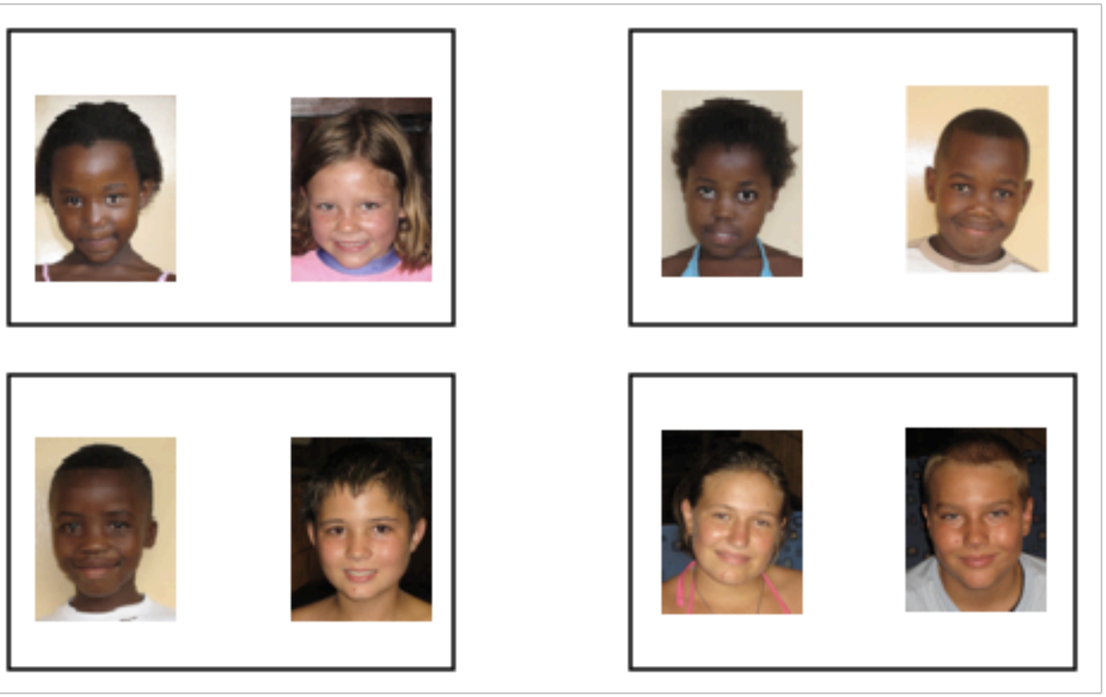
https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=z0BxFRu_SOw

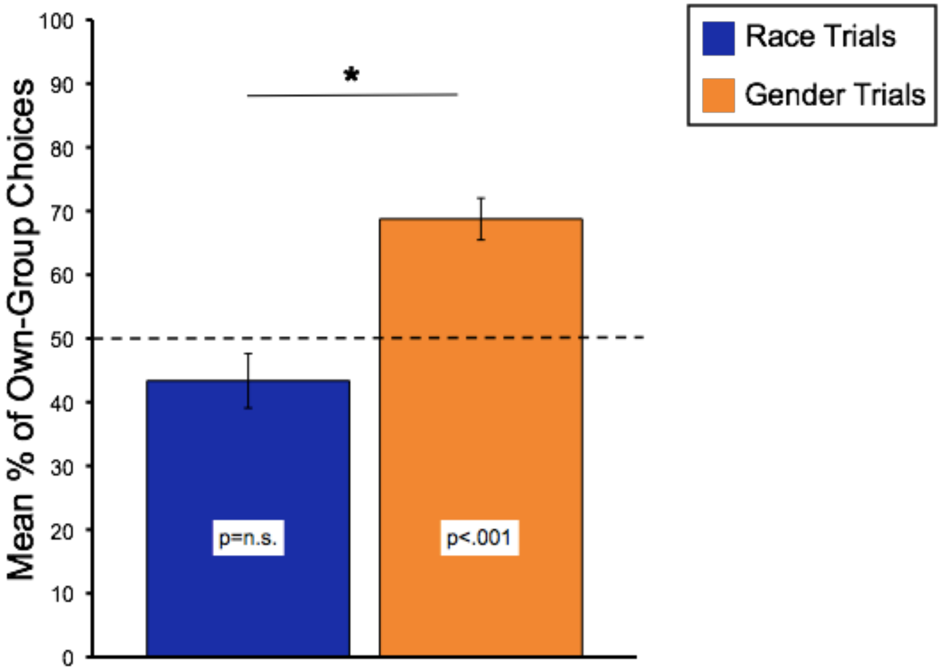
(Kiri Davis, short documentary, *A Girl Like Me*)

Asymmetries in racial attitudes

- South Africa: racial make-up contrasts with the U.S., but status differences look like the U.S.
- Participants: Xhosa 7-year-olds

Race Trials **Gender Trials**





Whom do you want to be friends with?

(Shutts et al., 2011; Qian, Heyman, Quinn, Messi, Fu, & Lee, 2016)

Sources of individual differences in racial prejudice

Intergroup contact

- Question: does intergroup contact affect racial prejudice?

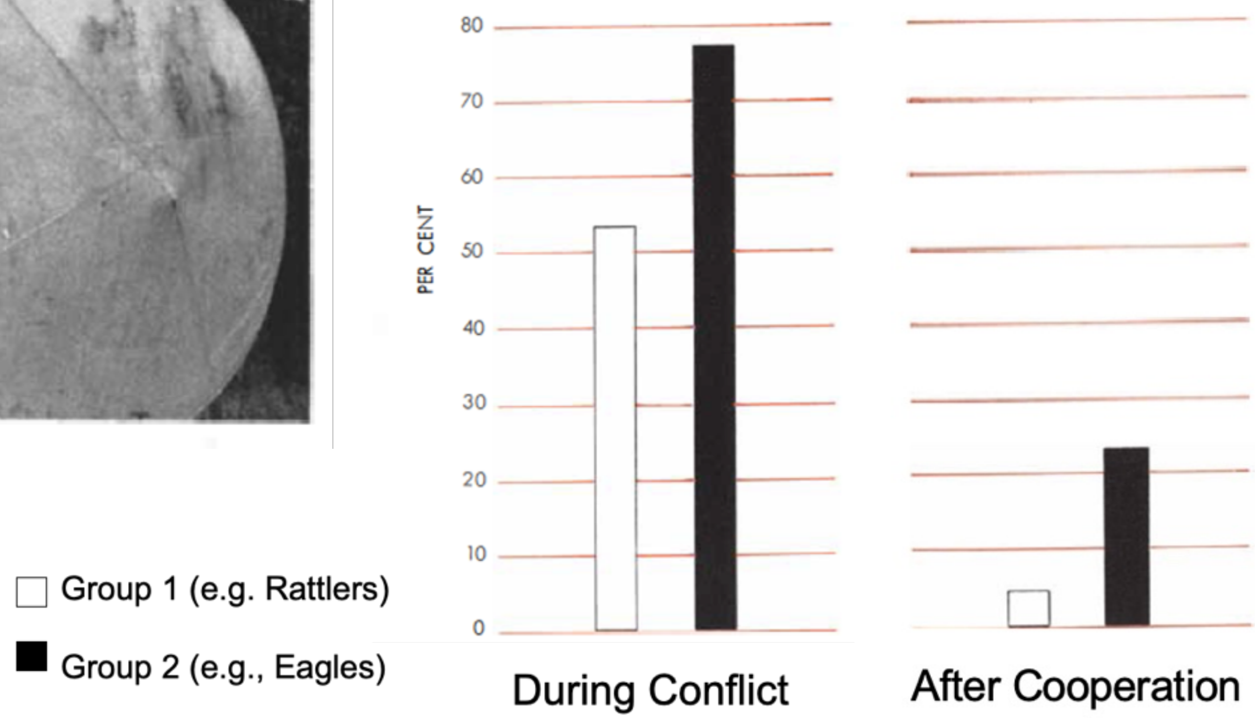
The case of Singapore…

(Turner et al., 2007; Hwang, Debnath, Meyer, Salo, Fox, & Woodward, 2021)

Cooperative contact

- Question: does cooperative contact (vs. mere exposure) reduce outgroup negativity?

% of kids who said negative traits apply to all members of other group



(Sherif, 1954)

Sources of individual differences in racial prejudice

Transmission from parents and trusted adults

- Question 1: is there a correlation between parents' and children's racial attitudes?
- Question 2: do adults' nonverbal behaviors influence children's racial attitudes?

(Castelli et al., 2008, 2009)

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www.psychologicalscience.org/PPS
SAGE

Racial Awareness and Bias Begin Early: Developmental Entry Points, Challenges, and a Call to Action

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Department of Psychology, Northwestern University

Abstract

Overt expressions of racial intolerance have surged precipitously. The dramatic uptick in hate crimes and hate speech is not lost on young children. But how, and how early, do children become aware of racial bias? And when do their own views of themselves and others become infused with racial bias? This article opens with a brief overview of the existing experimental evidence documenting developmental entry points of racial bias in infants and young children and how it unfolds. The article then goes on to identify gaps in the extant research and outlines three steps to narrow them. By bringing together what we know and what remains unknown, the goal is to provide a springboard, motivating a more comprehensive psychological-science framework that illuminates early steps in the acquisition of racial bias. If we are to interrupt race bias at its inception and diminish its effects, then we must build strong cross-disciplinary bridges that span the psychological and related social sciences to shed light on the pressing issues facing our nation's young children and their families.

embracerace

Ages & Stages: A Caregiver's Guide to Supporting Children's Racial Learning

Children are noticing, asking, and learning about race every day. Our Ages & Stages Guide shows you how to meet them where they are— at every age!

https://www.embracerace.org/resources/ages-stages-a-caregivers-guide-to-supporting-childrens-racial-learning

Go try a few Implicit Association Tests.
You will probably be biased.

https://implicit.harvard.edu/

Children are a kind of indicator species…
If we can build a successful city for children,
we will have a successful city for all people.